OF ONE DANCING GIRL AND THEN TWO MORE

Miyan Bayazid Baz Bahadur Khan, Sultan of Malwa, was a man who, by all accounts, enjoyed a life of leisure. The son of a governor under Sher Shah Sur, Baz Bahadur had demonstrated rather admirable warrior qualities, and had set himself up as the sultan after killing all his brothers. But after a short interlude attending to administrative affairs he would ‘enter the harem and after his meal…occupy himself with singing and music’. One of the courtesans he most famously enjoyed singing with, and writing Hindi poetry for, was Roopmati.* According to a popular contemporary legend, Roopmati herself ‘advised her lover to sacrifice pleasure and luxury for a season and bestir himself to set the affairs of his kingdom in order’ when news arrived of the Mughals at their frontier. But ‘too drunk to recognize day from night’, according to Abu’l Fazl, ‘he occupied himself with song and music’. The Mughals, for their part, justified the attack on the rich province of Malwa by claiming rather damningly that Baz Bahadur occupied himself with ‘unlawful and vicious practices’ and a Mughal force under Adham Khan was dispatched to Malwa in April 1561, ‘to spread justice and be balm for the wounds of the oppressed’.

Despite much harrumphing by Abu’l Fazl about the ‘tyranny and injustice Baz Bahadur had wrought upon the people of Malwa’, Adham Khan had been sent to Malwa at least partly due to the presence of elephants in the region, a source of wealth in themselves, and the treasured prerogative of kings. After Timur’s sack of Delhi, one of the governors of the crumbling Tughlaq dynasty had declared himself ruler of this rich, landlocked region in west-central Hindustan in the early fifteenth century. The fort of Mandu, set on a plateau, was greatly enhanced by successive rulers, and elephants were acquired from the forests in the east to compensate for a lack of war horses. The Khaljis eventually took over as sultans of Malwa in the mid-fifteenth century, continuing to invest in architecture in the province. By the time Akbar turned his attention to the region, a plenitude of war elephants and a distinctly Persianate culture were what Malwa had inherited and what Adham Khan had been sent in search of.